

Deconstructivism: Guggenheim Museum Bilbao

Architect: Frank Gehry

Style: Deconstructivism

Building: Guggenheim Museum Bilbao

Location: Bilbao, Spain

Year Built: 1997

The Style - Deconstructivism

- Deconstructivism is an architectural style that uses unusual, fragmented, and irregular forms.
- Buildings often use asymmetry instead of traditional symmetry.
- Shapes may appear to be broken apart or rearranged.
- Architects uses unexpected angles, curves, and forms.
- The building can look more like a piece of sculpture than a traditional building.
- Frank Gehry is one of the architects associated with this style.
- The Guggenheim Museum Bilbao is a good example because its unusual curves and fragmented forms make it very different from traditional museums.

Architect Biography - Frank Gehry

- Frank Gehry was born in 1929 in Toronto, Canada.
- He moved to Los Angeles in 1947.
- He studied architecture at the University of Southern California.
- Gehry started his own architecture practice in 1962.
- He became known for using unusual materials and creating unconventional building forms.
- He won the Pritzker Architecture Prize in 1989.
- Some of his most famous buildings include the Guggenheim Museum Bilbao and Walt Disney Concert Hall.
- Gehry's architecture is often recognized for its dramatic and sculptural form.



The Building - Guggenheim Museum Bilbao

- Architect: Frank Gehry
- Year Built: 1997
- Function: Art museum
- Location: Bilbao, Spain

- The Guggenheim Museum Bilbao was designed by Frank Gehry and completed in 1997.
- The building is located beside the Nervión River. Its exterior uses titanium, glass, and limestone.
- The building's unusual form includes curved walls, irregular shapes, and large pieces that appear to overlap and connect.
- The museum's design was intended to make the building itself an important part of Bilbao's cultural identity.

Architecture Terms

- **Symmetry:**
  Symmetry means that two sides of a design are similar or mirror each other. The Guggenheim does not rely heavily on symmetry.
- **Asymmetry:**
  Asymmetry means the two sides or parts of a design are different. The Guggenheim strongly uses asymmetry, with irregular shapes and different-sized sections.
- **Proportion:**
  Proportion is the relationship between the sizes of different parts of a building. Gehry uses different-sized forms to create a dramatic appearance.
- **The Golden Rectangle (ratio):**
  The Golden Rectangle is a rectangle based on the **golden ratio**, approximately 1:1.618. The Guggenheim is not primarily for being designed around the Golden Rectangle; instead, Gehry intentionally uses irregular proportions to create its Deconstructivist appearance.

Scale, Form, Function

- **Scale:**
  Scale refers to the size of a building or architectural element in relation to people and its surroundings. The Guggenheim has a large scale, making it stand out along the river and within the city.
- **Form:**
  Form is the overall shape and physical appearance of a building. The Guggenheim’s curved, fragmented, and irregular form is one of its most recognizable features.
- **Form Follows Function:**
  This means the shape of a building should be determined by what the building needs to do. The Guggenheim partly follows this idea because its interior spaces must function as galleries, but Gehry also made the exterior form a major artistic statement.
- **Function Follows Form:**
  This is almost the opposite idea: form comes first, and the function is designed around it. The Guggenheim is a good example to discuss because Gehry's dramatic sculptural form is so important that the museum's spaces had to be organized around it.

Why I Find the Guggenheim Interesting

- I find the Guggenheim Museum Bilbao interesting because it does not look like a traditional museum.
- Its asymmetry makes the building feel unpredictable, while its unusual form makes it look almost like a giant sculpture. The different proportions of the building's sections create a dramatic appearance.
- I also find its scale interesting because the museum is much larger than the people around it, making it stand out from its surroundings.
- The Guggenheim is especially interesting because it challenges the idea of form follows function. Instead of making the function the only thing that determines the design, Gehry made the building’s form an important experience itself.
- I believe that the building shows architecture can be both functional and artistic.

citations

- Guggenheim Museum Bilbao — The Building
- Guggenheim Museum Bilbao — Frank Gehry Biography
- Guggenheim Museum Bilbao — The Construction
- The Pritzker Architecture Prize — Frank Gehry
- Guggenheim — Architecture